Is Test cricket as close to administrators' hearts as they say it is? Possibly not. The five-day game is declining in one sense, because it is not making money in many countries. It is a difficult discussion, due to the emotions it evokes, but my thinking was refined by a conversation with Ryan ten Doeschate, my captain at Essex, whom I get on really well with.

Tendo is a fascinating bloke, whose approach to life is summarized by his Twitter bio, which contains only the quote: 'Take the risk of thinking for yourself, much more happiness, truth, beauty, and wisdom will come to you that way.' He's South African-born, is aged thirty-nine, and one of the best players to represent a non-Test playing nation, the Netherlands. His career is best described as esoteric. An Essex cricketer since 2003, after being spotted in South Africa by Graham Gooch, he has played for the following teams since 2010: Mashonaland Eagles, Canterbury, Tasmania, Kolkata Knight Riders, Impi, Otago, Chittagong Kings (now Vikings), Gazi Tank Cricketers, Adelaide Strikers, Dhaka Dynamites, Karachi Kings, Comilla Victorians, Rajshahi Kings and Lahore Qalandars.

He helped Balkh Legends win the inaugural Afghanistan Premier League in Sharjah in late October 2018, and ended the year playing for Bhairahawa Gladiators in the Everest Premier League, a six-team tournament in Nepal that stages all matches on three wickets at the Tribhuvan University ground in Kirtipur, just outside Kathmandu.

Despite that CV, he had dedicated his sporting life to Essex. He struggled badly on arrival; his bowling, which had been spectacularly successful because of his mastery of the yorker, went to pot for a while. I once saw him, head in hands, after being hit to all parts by Scott Styris in a match against Middlesex and wondered whether he would survive. He went out and won us that game with the bat and has never looked back. He is a fantastic leader of men, as comfortable discussing the past with county legends such as Goochy, Keith Fletcher and Doug Insole as he is playing cards on the bus or in the dressing room with an up-and-coming teenager. He has that knack of being able to relate to people on a variety of levels.

His wider views, then, carry weight. As an England player, I argued that there was a need to protect Test cricket proactively by redirecting some of the marketing budgets used to promote the white-ball form of the game. Tendo disagreed, on the principle that Test cricket is a business, like any other. It is impossible to protect a business from market forces. Shield it artificially for ten years, and the money men will still be cynical about its